

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-08-04

1 tional Spiritual Assemblies that the iranian ambassadors in their respective
countries have now acknowledged that mr. rúẏu'lláh rawẏání, whose
2 execution the iranian authorities originally denied, was indeed hanged in
3 mashhad on 21 j uly 1998, as reported in our letter of 22 july to National
4 Assemblies. The justification given for mr. rawẏání's brutal killing is that
he was convicted of "criminal acts against national security."

5 As you are aware, the charge against mr. rawẏání and his long incarcera-
6 tion bore no relation to any question of national security; they arose out 279.5

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281 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

282 68of the accusation that he had converted a young muslim woman to the

283 bahá'í faith. This young woman has made it clear that she is not a religious

284 convert, but was raised as a bahá'í by her mother, who is herself a member

285 of the faith. it is reasonable to conclude that the sudden introduction of

286 an entirely fictitious charge related to national security represents a belated

287 attempt by iranian authorities to fend off criticism from other governments,

288 the media and human rights agencies, and to provide a plausible excuse for denying
access to relevant information and documentation.

289 included in the statements from the iranian embassies is a report that

290 mr. rawẏání had been arrested "for the same reasons" (i.e. violations of

291 national security) twice before. . . . the facts of mr. rawẏání's earlier two

292 arrests leave no doubt as to how completely baseless are the charges now

293 brought against his memory:

294 1) mr. rawḡání was first arrested in 1984 as a former member of
295 the local Spiritual Assembly of cháhishk, a village near mashhad.

Although all bahá'í administrative bodies had been dissolved

296 in response to an order from iran's Attorney general in 1983,

some forty friends, including mr. rawḡání, were arrested on the

297 retroactive charge of having previously been members of Assemblies and bahá'í
committees in the mashhad region. mr. rawḡání

served more than a year in prison, over two years' internal exile in

Najafábád, near í fahán, and was compelled to pay a fine of over

298 one million rials before being permitted to return to his home.

299 2) mr. rawḡání's second arrest occurred approximately four years

ago. with the dissolution of their administrative institutions, the

believers found themselves having to make informal arrangements

300 for the conduct of such purely religious activities as Nineteen day feasts, children's
classes, prayer meetings and the like. it was

301 mr. rawḡání's involvement in one such planning meeting that occasioned his second
arrest. he, like all the others taken into cus-

302 tody on that occasion, was released after twenty-four hours.

303 until recently, the iranian authorities have done relatively little to con-

304 ceal the fact that bahá'ís are arrested, tried, sentenced and punished solely

305 on the grounds of their religious beliefs and activities. The text of the judg-ment of
the appeals court in the cases of mr. j amáli'd-dín pájípúr and

306 mr. m an'úr mihrábí, forwarded to you with our letter of 21 may 1998,

307 makes it clear that the official position of the government of iran and its 280.3

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282 69courts is that the bahá'í religion is itself “an illegal organization” and that a

283 person's membership in it makes him or her, by definition, liable to criminal

charges. The proceedings against messrs. rawḡání, pájípúr and mihrábí

284 make a mockery of the iranian government's assurances that, even though
 285 the bahá'í faith is not one of the religions recognized in the constitution of
 286 that country, iranian bahá'ís nevertheless retain the right to the observance
 287 of their religious beliefs. Activities such as "holding bahá'í feasts and meet-
 288 ings on 'b ahá'í life'" are brazenly adduced as evidence of criminal behavior,
 289 including "espionage" for foreign governments.

290 it may be noted in passing that these shameless proceedings in iranian
 291 courts against bahá'í citizens of the country violate fundamental provisions
 292 of iran's constitution, which guarantees written charges, the selection
 293 of legal representation, public trial, and verdicts which are reasoned and documented
 "with reference to the articles and principles of the law in ac-
 294 cordance with which they are delivered." . . .

295 in view of the efforts of iranian diplomatic spokesmen to suggest some
 296 significance in the fact that a bahá'í like mr. rawṣání has been arrested
 297 several times . . . most of the people arrested with mr. rawṣání on earlier
 298 occasions have likewise been arrested for a second or third time. The reason
 299 is related to the point made in our letter of 21 may 1998 that the province
 300 of khurásán (whose capital is mashhad) appears to have been selected as
 301 one of those regions in which a policy of particularly severe intimidation is being
 pursued. random arrests and imprisonment of believers who are
 302 seen as active in encouraging the religious life of the friends are apparently
 303 aimed at generating fear in the community as a whole. Alas, it now seems
 304 not unlikely that, as this intimidation had failed to produce any significant effect, the
 hanging of mr. rawṣání was decided upon as a demonstration of
 305 the seriousness of the authorities' determination to pursue the goals exposed

in the secret document drawn up in 1991 by the Supreme revolutionary
 306 **council.**

The current campaign of disinformation being carried on by iranian

307 embassies increases our concern about the safety of mr. 'A-á'u'lláh ḥamíd

Na'írízádih, mr. Sírús dhabíŷí-m uqaddam and mr. hidáyat-káshifí Na-

jafábádí, who were likewise sentenced to death in mashhad and are now

awaiting their fate after a farcical “retrial.”

308 with loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat 280.5

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281 Messages from The Universal House of Justice

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Bahá'í Sacred Literature in Simplified English

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]